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A New Framework for Comparative Study of Philosophy

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Abstract The aim of this essay is to outline a conceptual framework for a type of philosophy (or approach to philosophy) to be herein called "non-sentential philosophy." Although I will primarily concern myself with the conceptual coherence of the framework in this essay, illustrations will be provided to show that the notion has rich implications for comparative studies. In particular, I believe this theoretical framework will be of interest to those looking for a way to capture the differences between certain non-Western philosophical traditions—such as Chinese philosophy—and Western philosophy, a tradition in which the sentential approach is dominant.

Keywords Sententially-structured entity · Sentential predicates · Sentential philosophy · Non-sentential philosophy · Chinese philosophy

The aim of this essay is to outline a conceptual framework for a type of philosophy (or approach to philosophy) to be herein called "non-sentential philosophy." Although I will primarily concern myself with the conceptual coherence of the framework, illustrations will be provided to show that the notion has rich implications for comparative studies. In particular, I believe this theoretical framework will be of interest to those interested in finding a way to capture the differences between certain non-Western philosophical traditions—such as Chinese philosophy—and Western philosophy, a tradition in which the sentential approach is dominant. The essay is divided into seven sections. Sections 1 and 2 define the notion of a sententially structured entity and that of a sentential predicate. The two notions are then employed in Section 3 to define the concept of a non-sentential philosophy. Section 4 provides two examples of non-sentential philosophy from contemporary philosophy. The difference between the new concept and certain familiar philosophical views is explained in Section 5. This is followed by a key section that shows why the new concept must be taken seriously. The concluding section provides further evidence for the fecundity of the framework.

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1 Sententially Structured Entities

Let us call an object a "sententially structured entity" if having roughly the structure of an indicative sentence is what makes the object the kind of thing it is. Some of the things that clearly satisfy this characterization include states of affairs, facts, information, propositions, sentences, theories (defined as sets of sentences closed under logical consequences), thoughts, the propositional content of visual experience, and the objects of propositional attitudes such as beliefs and desires. For the sake of convenience, and also for lack of a better term,[1] I will call these entities "SSE's" (short for "sententially structured entities"), and I will call the notions that refer to these entities "sentential concepts."

SSE's share some very unusual features in common. To begin with, SSE's bear an intimate relation to language, and to (indicative) sentences in particular. This feature of SSE's is best seen in the way we refer to them. It appears that reference to an SSE must always involve the use of a sentence that expresses that SSE. Take facts for example. Suppose that, during a conversation, I want to comment on the undeniability of a fact, for example the fact that Confucius died in 479 BCE. There are many ways to get this done. I can, for example, first express the fact by making the statement "Confucius died in 479 BCE," and then follow up by saying "That is undeniable." The demonstrative "that" in the sentence I used to make the statement refers back to the fact that I want to comment on. A second way is to refer to the fact by using a definite description, in the following way: I first say, "The fact which I am going to state is undeniable," and then follow up by stating the fact. Third, I could give an SSE a proper name in the way parents name their newborn child. For example, I could simply name the fact that Confucius died in 479 BCE "Fido," and use it to refer to the fact every time I need to talk about it. We could in principle do this with respect to all facts. But note that it does not follow from this that we can dispense with the expression "Confucius died in 479 BCE" (assuming one accepts Kripke's causal account of names). We will need it at the naming ceremony ("I hereby name the fact that Confucius died in 479 BCE 'Fido'"). At the least, we will need the expression to fix the reference of the name whenever confusion regarding the proper use of this name arises. Finally, I can simply use a grammatical device—called by linguists a "sentential nominal"—to do the job. A common sentential nominal in the English language is the so-called t-clause.[2] To name an SSE, you simply prefix the word "that" to the sentence that expresses the SSE to which you wish to refer. For example, to refer to the fact that Confucius died in 479 BCE, you simply prefix the word "that" to the sentence "Confucius died in 479 BCE." The result is a referential term "that Confucius died in 479 BCE," which names the fact. Note that the sentence "Confucius died in 479 BCE" is essentially involved in each of the four ways I might use in referring to the simple fact that Confucius died in 479 BCE. What is remarkable, however, is that this is not a unique feature of facts, but something facts share with all other SSE's.

Another key factor of SSE's is that they are structured entities. To say of an SSE that it is structured is to say at least the following: (1) the identity of an SSE is not determined solely by the constituents out of which it is made. The way the constituents are combined also matters; (2) SSE's have a non-mereological mode of composition (Armstrong 2000: 205).

[1] Nothing substantial hangs on the term "sentential"; readers may replace the phrase with something of their liking. For example, the phrase "propositionally structured entities" would serve my purpose equally well. In that case, what is called "sentential philosophy" in this essay would become "propositional philosophy"; *mutatis mutandis* for "non-sentential philosophy" and its cognates.

[2] Every natural language (including Chinese) has its own syntactical rules for the construction of a sentential nominal; I chose the English t-clause as an example simply because this essay is written in English.

That is, the relation between an SSE and its constituents is not the part-whole relation. Consider the second feature first. It is a basic principle of mereology that the part-whole relation is a many-one correspondence. That is, out of the same parts there is one and only one whole. It is easy to see that the relation between the constituents of an SSE and the SSE itself is not a part-whole relation. Given the constituents of any SSE, there might be more than one SSE (that is, the whole) that corresponds to the parts. For example, "John," "Mary," and "loves" are the parts out of which the sentence "John loves Mary" is made. But that is not the only whole that the three terms determine; the same terms also yield the distinct sentence "Mary loves John." As for the first feature, it might be said that an SSE is simply the set consisting of its constituents. So for example, the proposition that John loves Mary is simply the set consisting of John, Mary, and the relation love. But surely this cannot be right. The proposition that Mary loves John shares with that set the same constituents, and yet it is a totally different proposition. It is for this reason that philosophers who employ the notion of propositions use the set-theoretic notation of an ordered set to preserve this feature of propositions. Philosophers in the past tried to reduce certain types of SSE's to certain unstructured entities. For example, there have been attempts to show that a proposition is no more than the class of possible worlds at which it is true (for an example, see Stalnaker 1984). However, if propositions, like other SSE's, are structured entities, then it follows that they cannot be reduced to sets of possible worlds, which are not structured entities. Furthermore, if the mode of composition of SSE's is non-mereological in nature, then a theory of SSE's that would not recognize any relation beyond the mereological relation of part-whole will be an inadequate theory of the SSE's in question.

A third significant feature of SSE's is that their individuation requires very fine criteria, for which extensional accounts are inadequate. Sentences, for example, resist the preservation of truth by substitutivity in contexts such as quotation marks, and belief ascription is notorious for its "opacity." Propositions cannot be identified with their truth conditions, sets of possible worlds, and so forth. Thoughts cannot simply be identified with their truth conditional content. And finally, facts are intensional entities whose individuation requires a finer criterion than that which is needed for the individuation of events. To give an example: if you have hit an undercover policeman, then you not only hit a man; you also hit a cop. If the cop turns out to be your father-in-law, then that is a third fact, that is, your hitting your father-in-law. On the other hand, there is only one hitting, and describing it in different ways will not change that.

A fourth noticeable feature of SSE's is their ontological status. There are persuasive arguments showing that SSE's are ontologically irreducible to other things. Armstrong, for example, has argued convincingly that states of affairs cannot be reduced to their constituents (Armstrong 1997: chapter 8). And there has been a consensus, of late, that propositions cannot be identified with possible worlds, truth conditions, or other entities (for example, see Soames 1987). This is not the place for debate about the ontological status of SSE's; for the purposes of this essay, two quick points will suffice. First, my argument for the notion of non-sentential philosophy does not depend on the ontological irreducibility of SSE's. Second, metaphysical plausibility is not the only reason philosophers embrace SSE's; in most cases, they endorse them because by appealing to the notion of SSE's they can get a lot of philosophical work done.

A final feature of SSE's that is relevant to the thesis of this essay is their conceptual mutual dependence. It seems that we have no way of defining one type of SSE without helping ourselves to other types of SSE. Take the notion of a sentence for example (where we are thinking, as is often in philosophy, of a declarative sentence). There is no consensus as to how the notion of a sentence is to be defined. One suggestion is that a sentence is the

smallest linguistic unit that is capable of expressing a complete thought. Another is that a sentence is something that can be true or false. As definitions these suggestions are quite inadequate. For one thing, the definitions feature two other notions, that of thought and that of truth. This means that you will not know what a sentence is until you understand these two notions. Suppose you ask what kind of thing a thought is. The answer you are most likely to get is either that it is a proposition, or that it is a proposition grasped under some mode of presentation. Either way, in order to know what a thought is, you need to find out what a proposition is. The suggestion that a thought is something that can be true and false fares no better. The notion of truth and falsity involves the notion of a truth bearer, and if the truth bearer is identified with any SSE's, then we are back to square one. The vital importance of this last feature of SSE's will become clear when we come to issues related to the application of the notion of non-sentential philosophy.

The unique features of SSE's can be brought out further by comparing them to their logical complement, that is, the NSSE's. Let us call an object a "non-sententially structured entity" if having the structure of an indicative sentence is not what makes it the type of thing it is. One particular group of NSSE's claims our attention—material objects such as chairs and tables, words, simple concepts, mental images, and qualia (if there are such things) and other similar "raw feels." A mental image such as the face that flashes back in my mind is no more an SSE than the image of a person's face in a mirror. Such an image does not have a content that is sentential in structure, nor is it a structured entity in the sense an SSE is. Furthermore, a mental image cannot be true or false, nor can it logically entail other SSE's. The same thing can be said about other NSSE's.

2 Sentential Predicates

The uniqueness of SSE's is also shown in the way we talk about them. For example, we do not say of NSSE's such as tables, chairs, photons, protons, numbers, words, pains, itches, etc. that they are "true," "false," "*a priori*," "*a posteriori*," nor do we say that a chair is "coherent with" another chair, that one number is the "evidence for" another number, that an itch "justifies" another. Furthermore, we do not even predicate truth, falsehood, *a prioricity*, etc. of concepts of these things. For example, the concept of a chair is no more true than it is false, the concept of an integer is no more *a priori* than it is *a posteriori*, and the concept of pain does not stand in the relation of coherence to any other simple concepts.

It seems clear that certain terms in our language are preserved for the predication of SSE's and SSE's only. Let us call this class of predicates "sentential predicates." Sentential predicates seem to fall under four main categories. In the first place we have *classificatory sentential predicates*, and these can be further divided into two subclasses. First-order classificatory sentential predicates include notions such as "is a state of affairs," "is a fact," "is a belief," "is a proposition," "is a thought," and "is a sentence," and second-order predicates include expressions such as "is a propositional representation," "is a sentence-like thing," "is a sententially structured thing," "is something the naming of which requires a sentence," "is something that can be true and false," and so forth. The second category, *metaphysical/semantic predicates*, includes expressions such as "true," "false," "necessary," "possible," "impossible," "contingent," "tautological," and "contradictory." Note that modal terms such as "possible," "necessary," and "contingent" are also used to predicate of NSSE's. When thus used, they are typically called "*de re* modalities," in contrast to the modality of SSE's, which are called "*de dicto*." Our third category, *epistemic predicates*, includes predicate-expressions such as "*a priori*," "*a posteriori*," "certain," "indubitable,"

"justifiable," "reliable," "confirmable," "assertable," "rational," as well as relation-expressions such as "is coherent with," "is evidence of," "entails," "implies," "deducible," and so forth. The fourth or last category is made of *linguistic predicates*. Examples include "analyticity" and "syntheticity," which are predicates that we use to predicate SSE's of, as illustrated in the following examples: "Some deny that the proposition 'All bachelors are unmarried men' is analytic," "Both sentences are analytic," and "Kant claims that there are such things as synthetic *a priori* propositions."

Presumably, sentential predicates refer to sentential properties and relations. This means that a sentential predicate is used appropriately when predicated of SSE's and is not used appropriately when predicated of NSSE's. It also means that properties such as being true/false, *a priority*/*a posteriority*, coherence/incoherence, entailment, rationality, etc. cannot be properties of anything other than SSE's.

3 Non-sentential Philosophy

The word "philosophy," as used in contexts such as "I work in philosophy, not in history" refers to an academic discipline. The same word, however, is also used in "Plato's political philosophy," "the moral philosophy of the Stoic school," and "philosophy of mind in China in the sixth century." "Philosophy" in these contexts does not refer to philosophy the discipline; rather, it refers to philosophical theories. When the word "philosophy" is used in phrases such as "non-sentential philosophy" in this essay, it is this use of the word that I intend. But to serve my purposes, even this is too crude. I need to further distinguish three senses of the notion of a philosophy or philosophical theory, which are: (1) a theory of some subject S; (2) a class of homogenous theories of S that share the same basic presuppositions; and (3) theories of various subjects or issues conceivable within a philosophical tradition. With these distinctions in hand, we can now turn to the task of defining the concept of non-sentential philosophy.

The standard view on theory individuation is that theories are individuated by reference to their predicates (see Fodor 1974: 77–115, and Quine 1969: 26–68). This conception of a theory is what I will rely on in the discussion below. But before I can do that, I need to spell out some of the details of the standard view. Let us say that a theory is a set of interpreted sentences (together with its own logical consequences), and let us say that a sentence is interpreted if it has been specified what things are to be taken as the values of the variables that occur in it and satisfy the predicate letters therein. The nice thing about this definition of a theory is that it allows us to see simultaneously two critical features of a theory: the theory's domain of discourse, and the predicates that distinguish it from other theories.

In view of the account of theory individuation just outlined, it seems that we can simply say that a non-sentential philosophy does not assign SSE's as the values of variables and contains no sentential predicates. But such a definition is obviously inadequate, in view of the three senses of the notion of a theory that I pointed out earlier. To do justice to the facts, we need to have not only one, but three definitions of a non-sentential philosophy: the non-sententiality of an individual theory of some subject S, the non-sententiality of a class of homogeneous theories of S, and non-sententiality within a philosophical tradition. The three notions are defined in recursive manner as follows:

> NSP1: A philosophical theory of some subject S is a non-sentential one if and only if (1) no SSE's or notions of SSE's are included as members of its universe of discourse, and (2) no sentential predicates are included in the theoretical vocabulary of the theory.

NSP2: A class of homogeneous theories of some subject S is a non-sentential one if and only if (1) no SSE's are included as members of the universe of discourse of any of the theories in the homogeneous class, and (2) no sentential predicates are included in the theoretical vocabulary of any of the theories in the homogeneous class.

NSP3: A philosophical tradition is non-sentential if and only if (1) no SSE's or notions of SSE's are included as members of the universe of discourse of any of the theories conceivable in the tradition, and (2) no sentential predicates are included in the theoretical vocabulary of any of the theories in the tradition.

To smooth discussion, I will sometimes employ the phrase "non-sentential philosophy" and sometimes the term "non-sententiality" to cover all three senses defined above and let the context decide which one is under discussion. With the three definitions in place, it is also easy to construct their sentential counterparts. For example, SP1, the counterpart of NSP1, will go something like this: A philosophical theory of some subject S is sentential if and only if (1) its universe of discourse contains at least one SSE, *or* (2) its theoretical vocabulary contains at least one sentential predicate. A philosophy is sentential or has the property of sententiality whenever one of these two conditions is satisfied.[3]

4 Two Examples of SP1 Theories

Our newly defined concept merely says that it is conceptually possible that there are non-sentential theories. It would be nice if there actually are examples of this type of theory in contemporary philosophy. And this turns out to be the case. In what follows I describe two such cases. It must be emphasized that the two are by no means the only non-sentential theories there are. I chose them simply because they are the ones with which I happen to be familiar.

Case I. My first case concerns the metaphysics of events. Addressing the relation between the notion of a physical object (understood as four-dimensional) and that of an event, the philosopher Reichenbach once remarked that "a thing is a monotonous event; an event is an unstable thing." This idea was further developed by Russell and culminated in the work of Quine. According to Quine, "Physical objects, conceived thus four-dimensionally in space-time, are not to be distinguished from events or, in the concrete sense of the term, processes. Each comprises simply the content, however heterogeneous, of some portion of space-time, however disconnected and gerrymandered" (Quine 1960: 171). We may say that, on this view, an event is a triple (S, T, Z), with "S" standing for the set of particular things at time T in region Z; and two events are the same if they occupy the same space-time zone. We may call this the "Reichenbach-Russell-Quine Thesis." Several things make the theory stand out. First, the theory does not recognize anything other than concrete events (a thing is concrete if it is in space and time). This reflects what motivated the theory in the first place, that is, an attempt to identify events with four-dimensional physical objects. Second, because the notion of "total content of a space-time zone z at time t" can

[3] A word of warning. When I use phrases such as "a theory containing a sentential predicate" in the discussion below, I do not mean sentential predicates used by a philosopher in the statement or description of her theory. The language a philosopher uses in stating her theory is the meta-language, the theory she is stating or describing through the use of the meta-language—which may very well contain sentential predicates—is the object language. It is easy to confuse the two when one is dealing with a topic of this nature. Many misunderstandings can be avoided by paying attention to this simple distinction.

be taken to mean "totality of tropes at z," the notion of property is dispensed with in the theory.

That the Reichenbach-Russell-Quine Thesis is a non-sentential theory of events is obvious. Its non-sentential nature is especially clear when compared to two other theories of events, that is, the so-called Leibniz-Kim thesis, which basically says that an event is a property instance, and the theory of Jonathan Bennett, which basically defines the notion of an event in terms of facts. The Leibniz-Kim theory makes essential use of the notion of a property understood in its intensional sense, but Bennett's theory takes the notion of a fact to be conceptually prior to that of an event. Both these accounts are sentential, in contrast to the non-sentential nature of the Reichenbach-Russell-Quine thesis (my discussion here is heavily indebted to Jonathan Bennett 1988).

Case II. My second case concerns the issue of mental imagery. The phenomena that have given rise to the debate are familiar enough. It concerns entities that seem to be introspectively accessible, that is, mental images. Moreover, psychologists seem to have produced experimental results that seem to support the introspective data. It has been reported that subjects seem to be able to scan mental images and rotate them, that the scanning and rotating take time, and that the time needed for scanning and rotating is proportional to distance between spots to be scanned or degrees of angles needed to be rotated. How are data such as these to be explained? Two main positions seem to have emerged from the debate. One is often called "the descriptionalist view," according to which the so-called mental imaging is to be explained in terms of descriptional or propositional representation. The other may be called the "pictoralist view," according to which mental images are not explainable in terms of propositional or sentential representations (Block 1990; Tye 1988).

With these general remarks in mind, let us turn to a specific theory of mental imagery (call it "T") in the pictorialist school. According to T, mental images are mental representations not unlike photographic representations. They are intrinsic, psychologically primitive, and in sharp contrast to propositional or sentential representations. They are intrinsic because their status as representations is due solely to the fact that they and what they represent stand in nomological relations. They are psychologically primitive because, while the operations of other types of cognitive processes must be explained in terms of them, their own operations are not to be explained in terms of other cognitive processes. In other words, the explanation of the process called "mental imaging" lies outside the domain of cognitive science.

It is not difficult to see how positing the existence of this type of mental representation helps T explain data collected in introspection as well as psychological experiments. For example, since mental images are like photographs, spatial relations are intrinsic to this type of representation, and this explains the spatiality mental imagery seems to display. Because mental images preserve nomic properties of the represented, mental scanning and rotating takes time. If we add the hypothesis that visual perception and mental imaging share a common type of mental representations, T can also explain other experimental data such as the so-called oblique effect.

Needless to say, if T is to be even remotely plausible, a lot more will have to be said about it. For example, it will need to show that photographic representations are just as construed above, that mental images are photographic representations, that photographic representations are primitive in the sense of being impenetrable by sentential or descriptional representations. Defending T, however, is not my goal. The point I hope T will help to illustrate is that it is not implausible that mental imaging is a cognitive process based on non-sentential representations that are inexplicable in sentential terms. As far as I

know, there have been no knock-down arguments from the descriptionalist camp that show the implausibility of theories like T.[4]

5 How NSP Differs from Other Familiar Approaches in Philosophy

The notion of a non-sentential philosophy is a unique one, and the best way to show this is by comparing it with other well-known and well-demarcated approaches in philosophy. For the sake of simplicity, let us use a particular philosophical subject, say the ontological issues concerning the mental, as the focal point of our discussion.

To begin, a non-sentential theory of mind is not the same as a reductionist theory of mind. Reductionism is the claim that all special sciences reduce to physics. In particular, reductionism in psychology is the view that, for every predicate that features in some laws of psychology, there is a predicate in physics to which it reduces (meaning a law in a psychological theory featuring a predicate F can be deduced from a law in physics featuring a predicate G). Psychological reductionism thus entails that sentential predicates such as "is a belief," "is a thought," "is a reason for acting," etc., reduce to some predicates in physics. A non-sentential theorist might find this part of the reductionist project congenial to her position, but would have no reason to go along with the reductionist in the latter's attempt to reduce *all* mentalistic notions to physical ones. In particular, their position does not require them to give up notions such as pain, sensation, or non-conceptual content (if there is such a thing).

It is clear that a non-sentential theory of mind might not be a physicalist theory of mind. Physicalism takes two forms. The weaker version says that all the events a special science talks about are physical events. The stronger version says that all properties that are referred to in special sciences are physical properties. The non-sententialist can accept the physicalist view as long as the events and properties at stake are sentential events and sentential properties, but she would not be required to accept the view that all events and properties, including non-sentential but mentalistic ones, such as an instance of pain and the property of being in pain, are physical events and physical properties.

It is also clear that a non-sentential theory of mind might not be an eliminativist theory of mind. Eliminativists such as psychological behaviorists and radical eliminativists about propositional attitude notions believe that psychological theories that utilize the mentalistic terms of folk psychology are false theories, based on an unacceptable ontology. Both the non-sentential theorist and the eliminativist reject talk of propositional attitudes. However, unlike the eliminativist, the position of the non-sentential theorist does not commit her to rejecting talk of mentalistic but non-sentential entities such as pains, itches, mental images, etc.

Finally, a non-sentential theory of mind might not be an extensionalist theory of mind. Extensionalism is the belief that a language that contains only extensional terms is sufficient for scientific purposes. Extensionalists claim that, rather than employing properties and the predicates that refer to them, science can do just as well with extensional notions such as that of sets, sets of sets, etc.; and that instead of relying on notions of

[4] Space does not allow a separate section on non-sentential theories in the sense of SP2. So a quick mention of two contemporary examples of SP2 theories will have to suffice: Behaviorism in psychology (and its kin Philosophical Behaviorism, which is associated with Gilbert Ryle), and connectionism in the contemporary study of cognition. The two are examples of SP2 because each is an approach not just to the study of individual issues but to the study of human psychology in general, and because these theories aim to explain cognition (and other psychological phenomena) without using any notion of SSE's.

propositionally structured entities such as states of affairs and facts, scientists can get by with only terms that refer to non-propositional objects and particulars. A non-sentential philosophy need not take issue with theories that employ intensional terms as long as these terms do not refer to SSE's. For example, a non-sentential philosophy of mind will have no particular reason for objecting to the use of terms such as "pain," "sensation," "mental image," and so forth in a philosophical theory of mind.

6 Significance of the New Concept

If all there is to the notion of a non-sentential philosophy were its logical coherence and conceptual uniqueness, then the notion would have little to recommend itself. But I hope that what I said in the previous section is an indication that this is not the case. At the minimum, when used as a criterion for grouping theories, the framework delivers the correct result—theories that are regarded as different come out as being different when viewed from this new framework. Not only that, the criterion used to identify the theories provides a vantage point that is potentially significant for the purpose of theory assessment.

A virtue of the notion of a non-sentential theory is its ability to help identify a particular type of theoretical commitment by a theory, namely, its commitment/non-commitment to SSE's. Exposing the theoretical commitment of a theory is a necessary step toward assessing its strengths and weaknesses. As an illustration let us consider again theories of events. We know that ontological entities such as facts, states of affairs, situations, and propositions are treated by most philosophers as SSE's and issues relating to these entities are formulated in sentential terms, and they are so treated for good reasons. The notion of a fact is a case in point. To begin with, facts are widely regarded as SSE's. Secondly, the view that facts are SSE's is closely related to the search for a truth-maker, the thing that makes a true sentence true. This renders the issue of facts a mere instance of a more general issue regarding the nature of similarly structured entities. Viewed from this perspective, the Leibniz-Kim theory, which takes events to be SSE's, comes out an ontologically much simpler and more economic theory, since it posits just one, not two, ontological kinds. Furthermore, it is a theory that allows for a greater unification for a wide range of theories, since it uses the same theoretical apparatus for events as well as for facts, states of affairs, situations, and so forth. In contrast, because the Reichenbach-Russell-Quine Thesis treats events as NSSE's, it is committed to two, not just one, ontological kinds.

The point I am trying to make here is not that merely being sentential renders a theory less plausible, or vice versa, but rather that the distinction between a sentential and non-sentential theory is one capable of revealing a particular type of theoretical commitment. Whether a particular commitment is a defeater/underminer is not an issue addressed here. My discussion, however, does raise important questions: "How do we decide whether a philosophical issue is sentential or non-sentential?" "What does it mean to call a philosophical issue sentential/non-sentential?" "What kind of subject or issue can a non-sentential theory be a theory about?" The rest of this section is devoted to these questions.

The status of many issues as philosophical issues depends essentially on the existence of SSE's or the use of some notions of an SSE and sentential predicates. Let us call these "sentential issues" (an issue is non-sentential if it is not sentential). From the perspective of this article, we may divide sentential issues into three classes. The first consists of issues that concern the ontological and epistemological status of SSE's themselves. Typical examples of this class include questions such as: "What are states of affairs?" "Do facts exist in space and time?" "How do we come to know a proposition?" The relation between this type of problem

and the notion of an SSE is straightforward: Had you not assumed the existence of such entities, or had you not presupposed the existence of such entities, the issue of what these things are and how we come to know them would have never arisen. There cannot be non-sentential theories of propositions, facts, states of affairs, beliefs, sentences, etc.

The second class of sentential issues consists of issues that have to do with properties of and relations between SSE's. Examples of this class include questions such as: "Does "truth" denote a substantial property?" "What is the relation of correspondence (as used in the correspondence theory of truth)?" "Is Plato correct in asserting that knowledge is 'justified true belief'?" "In what does the relation 'coherence' consist?" The relation between this type of question and the notion of an SSE may not be as straightforward as that between the same notion and members in the first class, but it is the same relation notwithstanding. Coherence, for example, can only be a relation between SSE's; things such as words, simple concepts, mental images, oranges and apples, etc. do not stand in such relation to each other. The same thing can be said about "true." Obvious as it is, this fact can be overlooked. Notions such as "correspondence" etc. often serve as a reminder as to what is at stake, but when claims such as "to be true is to be useful," or "to be true is to be evolutionarily advantageous" get tossed into the debate, one can sometimes forget that what is said to be useful, advantageous, etc., are really nothing but SSE's, i. e., sentences, statements, proposition, beliefs, and theories. Since the formulation of these issues depends on notions of SSE's, there cannot be non-sentential theories of truth, just as there cannot be non-sentential theories of propositional knowledge or non-sentential theories of epistemic relations such as coherence.

The relation between the third class of sentential issues and the notion of an SSE is buried much deeper than in the previous two classes. Nonetheless, the relation is present and unmistakable. I will briefly mention one such case here, the issue of practical rationality. "Rational" is a term that we use to talk about persons and their acts. Appearances to the contrary, the issue of rationality is deeply wedded to SSE's and notions of SSE's, and this should come as no surprise. After all, the concern of practical rationality is action, or what we do for a reason. But what we do for a reason is a matter that is essentially tied to what we take to be the case, what we desire, and we will decide to do. So it appears that in order to talk about rationality, there must be notions for at least two types of representations, one to represent the agent's goals, and the other to represent the causal relations between states of affairs. Both representations essentially involve SSE's such as belief, desire, and intention. The issue of practical rationality, it turns out, cannot be an issue for a non-sentential philosophy.

So there appear to be a large number of familiar (some will probably say "core") issues that a non-sentential theory cannot be about. But this does not mean that a non-sentential theory is insignificant. The two examples of non-sentential theory I discussed in the previous section should have made this clear. However, let me now make this point more general. Let us call a philosophical issue non-sentential if its formulation does not require the use of notions of SSE's or does not presuppose the existence of SSE's. There is a large number of topics the discussion of which does not require the use of SSE's and are open to both sentential and non-sentential approaches. Here are some examples: "What is it like to be in pain?" "What is it that a person knows when she knows how to ride a bicycle?" "What is it like to see colors?" Questions such as these can even be raised by someone who outlaws sentential notions from her theory.

What is the relation between the two types of issues? It is plausible to say that while it is very unlikely that a sentential issue will turn out to be a non-sentential one, it may be not impossible for a sentential theorist to claim that some of the alleged non-sentential issues

are actually sentential ones. Consider the relation between "knows-that" and "knows-how," and compare the following three claims: (1) All alleged instances of "knows-that" are, or can be reduced to, instances of "knows-how"; (2) Some alleged instances of "knows-how" are, or can be, understood in terms of "knows-that"; and (3) There is at least one type of "knows-how" that cannot be reduced to or explained in terms of "knows-that." It seems pretty clear that while claim (1) does not seem plausible, both claims (2) and (3) stand a good chance of being true.

At this point, it is tempting to draw the conclusion that the relation between the two types of issues is asymmetrical. The truth, however, is more complicated. While it is true that issues such as "What kind of property does 'truth' express?" are conceptually dependent on the notion of an SSE, it is not clear that all philosophically significant topics are like that. It is not obvious, for example, that the status of what we might call "consciousness-related" issues are the same type of issues as that of truth. And if this is the case, then it must be admitted that there exists a no-man's land where anything found is open simultaneously to both sentential and non-sentential approaches, and the score can only be settled by comparing theories and determining which one is the best (on account of having greater unifying power, economy, explanatory power, etc.). In light of this, it seems reasonable to distinguish philosophical topics from philosophical issues. The former are philosophical problems that "present themselves to a theorist" and are therefore—at least initially—open to both the sentential and the non-sentential approaches. Issues, on the other hand, are the result of a theorist "putting questions to Mother Nature," and they come in two subgroups: the strictly sentential ones and the rest. Of these two, the strictly sentential ones are not open to a non-sentential approach. The second group, on the other hand, is open to both, and any dispute that arises must be settled on the basis of a theory's ability to make sense of the topic. On this account, whether the relation between sentential issues and non-sentential ones is asymmetrical or not depends entirely on whether there will turn out to be essentially non-sentential topics or not—that is, topics that are incapable of sentential treatment. I have no plans to go into this issue here but do strongly believe that there are such philosophical topics. Anyone who has doubts about this need only ask themselves this question: "Do I have to believe that I am in pain in order to feel pain?"

It appears that not only are there issues whose very formulation does not require the use of any sentential notions, but that there are issues that are simply not open to the sentential approach. If we accept this—and I see no reason why we should not—then the real issue is how much of the philosophical terrain is or can be subject to a non-sentential treatment. I do not have a complete list of issues open to a non-sentential approach, but I am inclined to think that a comprehensive list would include a wide range of issues ranging from metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of mind, to moral philosophy. Here are a few samples: metaphysical issues such as mereology, colors, and the nature of events; epistemological issues related to certain types of skills or abilities; issues in moral philosophy, such as "In what does courage consist?" "What is it to be temperate?"; qualia or conscious experience related issues (pain, the experience of seeing colors, etc.); and the study of the intentionality of intentional objects with nonpropositional content, such as problems related to concepts and mental imagery.

7 Implications for Comparative Study of Philosophy

The focus of the essay so far has been on the conceptual coherence of the notion of a non-sentential philosophy. An issue that I have not addressed is whether there could be a

philosophical tradition which is chiefly non-sentential in the sense of NSP3. I am inclined to think that Chinese philosophy is one such tradition. A full length treatment of the subject is out of the question here, so some general remarks will have to suffice.

Let me start by going back to a claim I made in the opening paragraph of this essay where I announced that Western philosophy in general is an example of a sentential tradition. Now in saying that Western philosophy is dominantly sentential, I do not mean that every philosophical school of thinking that has ever emerged in that tradition is sentential, or that every issue ever raised and dealt with in that tradition is a sentential issue. After all, I used two examples from contemporary analytic philosophy in Section 4 to illustrate SP1 (and two examples of SP2 in a footnote in the same section). These examples notwithstanding, it remains true that Western philosophical tradition is a dominantly sentential tradition.

As philosophy teachers we tell our freshman students—when we are in a hurry—that contemporary philosophy "comprises analytic philosophy and Continental philosophy." Now the sentential nature of analytic philosophy needs no explanation, and I claim that a sentential approach is one of the strong currents that constitute what people loosely call "Continental philosophy." To see this, consider that you cannot talk about "Continental philosophy" without talking about the two methodologies which constitute its backbone, phenomenology and hermeneutics. Anyone who is familiar with the history of phenomenology knows that sentential issues are—from the very beginning—a proper concern of phenomenology. A good example is the issue known as "the intentionality of the mental." The initial systematic study of this issue dates back to later medieval scholasticism. The issue was further pursued in modern time by Franz Brentano and Edmund Husserl. By the time it got in the hands of contemporary analytic philosophers, it became known as the issue of intentionality of "propositional attitudes." This example shows that the idea of thinking being a relation between a thinker and an SSE has long been a shared view of the two traditions.

The same thing can also be said about hermeneutics. It is true that philosophers of hermeneutics use the word "language" in a much looser and wider sense than do analytic philosophers. The former would say their focus is "text" rather than "sentence," and they take the "context" within which a text is to be interpreted (lived, experienced, etc.) to include situations such as "the condition of being-in-the-world," "tradition," "community," "dread and fear," etc. This contrasts with the analytic philosopher's bone-dry notion of "truth-conditions." However, nothing in the hermeneutical notion of "text" implies that sentences, or sets of these, understood as something that can be true or false, are excluded from being the proper concern of a philosopher of hermeneutics. If this evidence from the heavy overlapping of issues in the two traditions is still not enough, consider the mutual influence between the two traditions in recent times (the exchange of ideas between Habermas and Putnam and Rawls, Derrida and Brandon are just a few prominent examples).

So much for my argument for the Western tradition's being a sentential one, but before I can offer support for my claim that Chinese philosophy is largely a non-sentential tradition, I need to get a similar worry out of the way. When I say that Chinese philosophy is a non-sentential philosophical tradition, am I saying that every bit of philosophical stuff that has ever been produced in that part of the world is non-sentential? The answer is of course "No!" What I claim is that "the hard-core Chinese philosophy" (or "HCCP" for short) is non-sentential. Which part of the Chinese tradition constitutes the HCCP? If you have someone who believes that Chinese civilization has produced philosophical ideas and theories, and who believes that these ideas and theories are unique in the sense that they are not just the repetition of what had been said somewhere else and said better, simply ask the

person for an example of what they mean by "unique Chinese contribution." Whatever this person identifies as a "unique contribution" will be part of what I mean by "HCCP."

If the HCCP core—whatever that is—is a sentential tradition, we should expect to see discussions of terms that were taken to refer to SSE's, to their sentential properties, and to their sentential relations; we should expect to encounter investigations of issues formulated in sentential terms. In the area of metaphysics for example, we should expect to see discussions of *truth-maker* related issues ("What are facts?" "What are states of affairs?" "What are propositions?" "What are the constituents of a fact, a state of affairs, or a proposition?"). In the area of epistemology, we should expect discussions of issues related to the notion of *propositional knowledge* and not just know-how types of issues. In the area of moral philosophy, we should expect discussions of meta-ethical issues such as "What is practical reasoning?" "What is moral reasoning?" "What is the foundation and nature of the general propositions featured in practical/moral reasoning?" In philosophy of mind, we should expect an approach that treats the mind as a type of semantic engine, and so forth.

However, one sees little of this in HCCP. The theoretical vocabulary of HCCP comprises a tight group of notions, which in most cases take a pair-wise form and allow no easy sentential interpretation. Consider the two tables on the following two pages, which are produced for purpose of illustration and not meant to be complete.

These tables reveal the algorithm employed in the generation of a typical topic in HCCP. A topic or an issue is generated by combining an item from Table 1 with one from Table 2. In principle, any combination of two items taken from the two tables qualifies as a "well-formulated formula," but historically, only some of these combinations caught on and became the main concerns of the tradition. Examples: "*zhi gong er yi si* 志公而意私 (aspiration is public-spirited while intentions tend to be of self-interest)," "*xin you shan er xing wu bu shan* 心有善惡, 性無不善 (good and evil pertain to mind but not nature)," "*xing shi xin zhi ti* 性是心之體 (nature is the foundation of mind)," "*dong chu shi xin dong di shi xing* 動處是心, 動底是性 (the mind is that which is moved, nature is that which moves)," "*xing shi wei dong qing shi yi dong* 性是未動, 情是已動 (Inactivity is the condition of Nature; its active phase is known as emotion)."

Whether the philosophical tradition that produced the two tables is sentential or not depends on the nature of the items. Should any turn out to be an SSE, or to express an SSE as defined in Section 2, the claim that HCCP is non-sentential will need to be reevaluated. But the non-sentential nature of the items in the two tables is obvious. In Table 2, the items

Table 1 Sample substantive terms

li 理 (principle)	*qi* 氣 (the physical)
li 理 (principle)	*qi* 器 (objects of instrumental value)
li 理 (principle)	*qing* 情 (emotion)
li 理 (principle)	*shi* 事 (affairs)
dao 道 (way)	*qi* 器 (objects of instrumental value)
wu 無 (non-being)	*you* 有 (being)
xing 性 (nature)	*qing* 情 (emotion)
zhi 志 (aspiration)	*yi* 意 (intention)
xing 性 (nature)	*xin* 心 (mind)
xing 性 (nature)	*xiang* 相 (characteristic)
daoxin 道心 (mind of dao)	*renxin* 人心 (human mind)
dexing zhi zhi 德性之知 (moral knowldge)	*wenjian zhizhi* 聞見之知 (perceptual knowledge)

Table 2 Sample predicate expressions

jin 靜 (inactivity)	*dong* 動 (activity)
xu 虛 (void)	*shi* 实 (full)
ti 體 (foundation)	*yong* 用 (application)
neng 能 (capacity)	*suo* 所 (physical basis of capacity)
weifa 未发 (not yet in motion)	*yi-fa* 已发 (already in motion)
qing 清 (clear)	*zhuo* 浊 (turbid)
xingershang 形而上 (without form)	*xingerxia* 形而下 (with form)
yi 一 (one)	*duo* 多 (many)
ben 本 (root)	*mo* 末 (branch)
shan 善 (good)	*er* 恶 (evil)

are just not the right ones to use when describing an SSE. For example: a proposition cannot be "static" or "in motion," nor can it be "void" or "filled," "already in action" or "not yet in action." The physical process or event through which the proposition is tokened or expressed may be said to be "static" or "in motion," "void" or "filled," "already in action" or "not yet in action," but not the proposition itself. The same can be said of sentences, beliefs, thoughts, and other sentential entities.

Items in Table 1 are supposed to be the subject of a topic statement when combined with an item from Table 2. But as we just saw, items in Table 2 are not sentential predicates but non-sentential predicates—an indication that the items in Table 1 are not SSE's. To drive the point home, consider the item *li* 理 in Table 1. I can imagine someone arguing that the standard English translation of this term is "principle," and the word "principle," in one use, refers to propositions (such as the "principia" in Newton's *Principia Mathematica*), or to something that is either true or false. It follows that *li* 理 is a notion that refers to something that can be true or false. But that is of course a *non sequitur*.

A better approach to the issue would be by way of looking at how the term *li* 理 is actually used in philosophical discussion in this tradition, and little suggests that it is used to refer to sententially structured entities. The use of this term in discussion of metaphysical issues is always coupled with the term *shi* 事 (affairs) or *qi* 气 (the physical), and the stock questions include "Could there be *li* without *shi*?" and "Is *li* prior to *qi*, or *qi* prior to *li*?" If *li* referred to something propositional, such questions would make little sense. Talk of *li* in moral philosophy quickly and invariably leads to talk of Confucian virtues, and talk of Confucian virtues dissolves into talk of physiological processes, bodily movement, and behavior. Again, if *li* were really a notion used to refer to something that has a sentential/propositional structure, you should expect discussions of issues relating to its various sentential/propositional properties as well as relations to other SSE's, namely issues such as "Is it true?" and "How do we know that it is true?" But we see little of that in works in this tradition. Similar things can be said about *dao* 道, *xin* 心, and other items in Table 1.

It has been the opinion of many that Chinese philosophy is fundamentally different from the mainstream Western tradition. But different how? Anthony Flew once complained that, thumbing through Wing-tsit Chan's (once widely used book) *A Source Book in Chinese Philosophy*, he could not find anything that would qualify as a philosophical issue (Flew 1979). Flew might be on to something, since no words ever issued from the mouths of the ancient Chinese masters and collected in that book remotely resemble what we find, say, in Plato, such as "Is justified true belief knowledge?" Herbert Fingarette applied some of J. L. Austin's ideas (in particular, Austin's notion of perfomative acts) to the interpretation of

Confucius's moral philosophy, and he was hailed for giving new insight into the master's philosophy of *li* (Fingarette 1998). Chad Hansen made a name for himself by arguing that the concept of truth is not part of the conceptual apparatus of Classical Chinese philosophy (Hansen 1985). David Velleman found Zhuangzi unique in that the latter employs a notion of action in which the standard (or Western) notion of practical reasoning (action understood as a result of interaction of sentential things such as belief, desire, and intention) is absent (Velleman 2008). The list goes on.

All these philosophers seem to be on to something, and my account of non-sentential philosophy as given in NSP3 provides a unifying answer to what it is. The Chinese tradition is built on a non-sentential framework in that it concerns itself with questions formulated only in non-sentential terms, and in that the answers are formulated in non-sentential terms. If we look at matters this way, Anthony Flew's disappointment is easily explained. He was looking in Chinese philosophy for a theoretical issue formulated in sentential terms (like the one Socrates asks in *Theaetetus*), and naturally he was disappointed. Similarly, Chad Hansen's claim that there is no "truth" in Chinese philosophy sounds a lot less outrageous when you view it as the claim that the notion of truth is not an item in what would be a complete Table 2 (i.e., not part of the topic-generating algorithm). On the other hand, those who were hailed for having brought new insight into the study of the Chinese tradition were so received because their works touched on the feature that has made this tradition unique.

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